

Worse Is Better, iPhone, and Android

Richard P. Gabriel's 'Worse Is Better' argues that systems emphasizing simplicity, ease of implementation, and practical adoption often spread farther than systems optimized for elegance, completeness, and theoretical correctness.

The Two Philosophies

The Right Thing (MIT Style): prioritize correctness, consistency, completeness, and elegant design. These systems are often harder to build but deliver a more coherent experience.

Worse Is Better (New Jersey Style): prioritize simplicity and ease of implementation. A system that is 'good enough' and easy to adopt can outcompete a more elegant alternative.

Apple: The Right Thing

Apple's iPhone strategy resembles 'The Right Thing.' Hardware, software, distribution, and UX are tightly integrated. Features are often introduced later, but with an emphasis on consistency and quality.

Outcome: less fragmentation, stronger optimization, and a predictable developer and user experience.

Android: Worse Is Better

Android resembles 'Worse Is Better.' It embraces openness, multiple manufacturers, diverse hardware, and rapid experimentation. The platform sacrifices uniformity in exchange for scale and flexibility.

Outcome: enormous adoption, rapid innovation, broad hardware diversity, and a vast ecosystem.

The Irony

The smartphone market became a real-world demonstration of Gabriel's thesis—and then complicated it. Android largely won the market-share battle by following the 'Worse Is Better' path, while Apple remained extraordinarily successful by following the opposite philosophy.

- Android powers most smartphones worldwide.
- Hardware manufacturers overwhelmingly choose Android because it is open and adaptable.
- The iPhone captures a disproportionate share of industry profits.
- Developers often target iPhone first because the platform is more uniform and predictable.

The Deeper Lesson

The outcome was not that one philosophy defeated the other. Instead, each dominated the area it was designed to optimize. Market share, profits, developer attention, and ecosystem control are different measures of success.

Android won ubiquity. It proved that a simpler, more flexible ecosystem can spread farther.

iPhone won consistency, profitability, and developer focus. It proved that a tightly integrated 'Right Thing' can outperform when quality, integration, and user experience matter more than maximum reach.

The smartphone industry ultimately validated both philosophies at the same time.